LETTERS ET AL

Is letter writing still relevant?

Maybe not, especially if we consider it in its “pure” form of putting pen to paper. Some exceptional cases may occur, like writing letters on rakshabandhan, to a friend moving to a new city, on someone’s birthday. But they are a rarity.

It may seem redundant now, in the age of digital media. What we need to remember is that we need to look at the content of the letter and not the form.

Emails HAVE replaced letters but basically follow the same format.

Informal letter

Sender’s address

Date (June 25, 2023 format)

Salutation

Body (divided in three paragraphs)

Subscription (Yours lovingly etc)

Name

FORMAL LETTER

Sender’s address

Date (June 26, 2023 format)

Receiver’s address

Subject

Salutation

Introductory paragraph

Body

Conclusion

Thanking You

Subscription (Yours faithfully, Yours truly, Yours Sincerely)

Name

Types of Formal Letters

- Letter to the editor
- Letter of complaint
- Cover letters
- Letters to university administration
- Letters of resignation, leaves etc

Things to include in a letter of complaint

- Give the basics: name, phone, order date and number
- Include your account number, if you have an account with the company.
- Give the product name and its serial or model number.
- Explain the problem.
- Give a brief history of your efforts to resolve the problem, if the information helps explain why you're writing to the company.
- Tell the company how you want to resolve the problem
- State the solution you want, like a refund, repair, exchange, or store credit. Or, consider asking the company to suggest a resolution.
- List the documents you're enclosing, if any. Remember — only send copies, not originals.
- Let them know how and when to reach you.
- Be reasonable

Letter to the editor

- Express your ideas clearly and concisely. It is a good idea to keep your letter no longer than 250 words.
- Confine yourself to one topic. Use simple words, short words, short sentences and short paragraphs. These make for easy reading. Your letter should be timely and newsworthy. Its meaning should be clear.
- Plan your first sentence carefully. Make it short and interesting. If you are able to allude to a news article or editorial in the paper addressed, your letter is more likely to be published.
- If you write to criticize, begin with a word of appreciation, agreement or praise. It is possible to be frank but civil. A calm, constructive presentation is persuasive. Vitriol puts your letter in the “crank” category.
- Help supply the truth that may have been omitted or slanted in reporting the news or editorializing on it.
- Use a relevant experience to illustrate a point. When rightly (and tightly) told, it can be persuasive.

Cover Letters

- A cover letter is a way to introduce yourself to organizations in a narrative form that will accompany your resume.
- describe your qualifications as well as your interest in both the job and organization so the employer will want to interview you. T
- Think of it as a brief SOP: fill the gaps in your resume with vital and interesting tit bits.
- Since the primary purpose of a resume and cover letter is to “market” you, always keep the organization’s hiring needs in mind.

Are cover letters redundant?

COVER LETTER TIPS

- Address your letters to a specific person if you can.
- Tailor your letters to specific situations or organizations by doing research before writing your letters. MAKE CONNECTIONS!
- **Mention the date and source of the advertisement, if responding to one. Can be a LinkedIn post as well,**
- Keep letters concise and factual, no more than a single page. Avoid flowery language.
- Give examples that support your skills and qualifications. **Use the STAR method.**
- Put yourself in the reader's shoes. What can you write that will convince the reader that you are ready and able to do the job?
- **A touch of humility is critical.**
- Don't overuse the pronoun "I". Remember that this is a marketing tool. Use lots of action words.
- If converting to a .pdf, check that your formatting translated correctly.
- Reference skills or experiences from the job description and draw connections to your credentials.
- Make sure your resume and cover letter are prepared with the same font type and size.

Sample outline

Opening paragraph: Clearly state why you are writing, name the position or type of work you're exploring and, where applicable, how you heard about the person or organization. Mention the key skills or expertise that qualify you for this role.

Middle paragraph(s): Provide supporting examples to demonstrate that you have the key skills and expertise needed in the role, which you have mentioned in the first paragraph; but do not reiterate your entire resume. Explain why you are interested in this employer and your reasonsfor desiring thistype of work. Be sure to do thisin a confident manner and remember that the reader will view your letter as an example of your writing skills.

Closing paragraph: Reiterate your interest in the position, and your enthusiasm for using yourskillsto contribute to the work of the organization. Thank the reader for their consideration of your application, and end by providing your email and phone number for any questions or to arrange an interview.

Are you a “self-motivated” “go-getter” who “thinks outside the box” and works “synergistically” in teams. Do you think of yourself as “dynamic” and a “problem solver”?

These are common clichés that ruin cover letters, draining them of life and meaning. Don’t use them. Instead, describe your work experience in concrete terms, and provide hard evidence of your achievements.

Bad Example

“I’m a self-motivated college student who thinks outside the box. In my current internship, I’m well known for being a problem solver who frequently comes up with dynamic solutions for complex problems.”

DYNAMIC WORDS TO INCLUDE IN YOUR CV/COVER LETTER

Familiarised

Rehabilitated

Allocated

Devised

Computed

Diagnosed

Interpreted

Cultivated

Synthesized

Arbitrated

Surveyed

Streamlined

Standardized

Retrieved

Generated

Facilitated

CV vs Resume: Is there a difference?

A resume is a brief, informative document summarizing your abilities, education, and experience. It should highlight your strongest assets and differentiate you from other candidates. Only one page long, use pointers frequently.

Used most frequently in academic settings, a CV (curriculum vitae) is also a summary of your experience and abilities, but a CV will include more credentials relevant to academia and research, such as publications, presentations, and references. More detail oriented, will include longer summaries and details of the projects that you have worked on.

Format of a CV

Personal details: Name, contact details

Educational Qualifications (Always in a Box)

Experience (Internships, college societies)

Academic achievements (positions in Olympiads)

Position(s) of responsibility

Extra-curricular activities (societies, volunteer work)

Skills: coding languages, web development, whatever that fits